

APPENDIX 3: CLINICAL OPIOID WITHDRAWAL SCALE (COWS) - LOG

CLINICAL OPIOID WITHDRAWAL SCALE Assessment form must be completed and signed before a dose can be administered							Addressograph					
Ward		Site										
	Baseline	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	
Date												
Time												
Resting pulse												
Sweating												
Restlessness												
Pupil size												
Bone or Joint aches												
Runny nose or tearing												
GI upset												
Tremor												
Yawning												
Anxiety or irritability												
Gooseflesh skin												
Total score												
Contact with Turning Point must be undertaken at the earliest opportunity												
Has contact with Turning Point been made?	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	
Dose required? (COWS $\geq$ 13)	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	Y / N	
Assessed by: Signature												
Print name												
Profession												

APPENDIX 3: CLINICAL OPIOID WITHDRAWAL SCALE (COWS) – GRADING

A Doctor should observe the patient during a 5-minute observation period then indicate a score for each of the opioid withdrawal signs listed below on the reverse of this chart. Add the scores for each item to obtain the total score.

Resting Pulse Rate: _____ beats/minute <i>Measured after patient is sitting or lying for one minute</i> 0 pulse rate 80 or below 1 pulse rate 81-100 2 pulse rate 101-120 4 pulse rate greater than 120	GI Upset: over last ½ hour 0 no GI symptoms 1 stomach cramps 2 nausea or loose stool 3 vomiting or diarrhea 5 Multiple episodes of diarrhea or vomiting
Sweating: over past ½ hour not accounted for by room temperature or patient activity. 0 no report of chills or flushing 1 subjective report of chills or flushing 2 flushed or observable moistness on face 3 beads of sweat on brow or face 4 sweat streaming off face	Tremor observation of outstretched hands 0 No tremor 1 tremor can be felt, but not observed 2 slight tremor observable 4 gross tremor or muscle twitching
Restlessness Observation during assessment 0 able to sit still 1 reports difficulty sitting still, but is able to do so 3 frequent shifting or extraneous movements of legs/arms 5 Unable to sit still for more than a few seconds	Yawning Observation during assessment 0 no yawning 1 yawning once or twice during assessment 2 yawning three or more times during assessment 4 yawning several times/minute
Pupil size 0 pupils pinned or normal size for room light 1 pupils possibly larger than normal for room light 2 pupils moderately dilated 5 pupils so dilated that only the rim of the iris is visible	Anxiety or Irritability 0 none 1 patient reports increasing irritability or anxiousness 2 patient obviously irritable anxious 4 patient so irritable or anxious that participation in the assessment is difficult
Bone or Joint aches If patient was having pain previously, only the additional component attributed to opioids withdrawal is scored 0 not present 1 mild diffuse discomfort 2 patient reports severe diffuse aching of joints/ muscles 4 patient is rubbing joints or muscles and is unable to sit still because of discomfort	Gooseflesh skin 0 skin is smooth 3 piloerection of skin can be felt or hairs standing up on arms 5 prominent piloerection
Runny nose or tearing Not accounted for by cold symptoms or allergies 0 not present 1 nasal stuffiness or unusually moist eyes 2 nose running or tearing 4 nose constantly running or tears streaming down cheeks	The COWS scale must be completed prior to each dose during the assessment period. Score: 5-12 = mild; 13-24 = moderate; 25-36 = moderately severe withdrawal. Scores of 13 and above are sufficient to warrant additional doses.

COWS scores can be undertaken to help establish withdrawal from Opioids and can be used in patient both ON or OFF a OST program.

COWS table has been adapted from Wesson (2003) The Clinical Opiate Withdrawal Scale (COWS)